

Why People Love Timer App but Still Leave

Lessons from fans, quitters, and wishlists — a mixed-methods study on retention, feature priority, and pricing strategy for a solo-developer product.

4,500

Total users

3,500

Paying subscribers

243

Quit responses analyzed

RESEARCHER

Grace Feng, PhD, MBA

METHODS

Survey · MaxDiff · Conjoint · Mixpanel

CLIENT

Timer App (pseudonym)

YEAR

2025

Three questions Philip couldn't answer alone

Timer App grew without marketing. The founder needed external research to understand what was happening — and what to do next.

R Q 1

What is the biggest obstacle for user retention?

Is it price, product quality, or something else?

R Q 2

What feature should a solo developer build next?

Most impact for least maintenance burden?

R Q 3

What family plan structure do users prefer?

How many seats, and how deep a discount?

Four data sources, triangulated

Each source contributed a different signal. Combining them creates a more complete picture than any one method alone.



Quit Survey

N = 243

Exit reasons from churned subscribers via in-app quit form



Simulated MaxDiff

8 features

Feature priority using real Canny forum votes as proxy



Simulated Conjoint

2 attr × 3 levels

Family plan pricing modeled from quit form signals



Mixpanel

3,500 users

Retention curves, device usage, geographic breakdown

A practice project that became a real business

Origin

Philip, a self-taught developer, built Timer App in November 2020 to learn to code. Never advertised. Users found it anyway — and paid.

The tension

Unexpected success brought an unexpected problem: Philip needed to know why users were leaving and which feature to build without burning out.

\$4.99

Monthly

\$39.99

Annual

FIG 1 — DEVICE DISTRIBUTION (N = 3,500 PAID)

Mac (MacBook / Monitor)

iPhone

iPad

FIG 2 — TOP TERRITORIES

US
USA

IN
India

CN
China

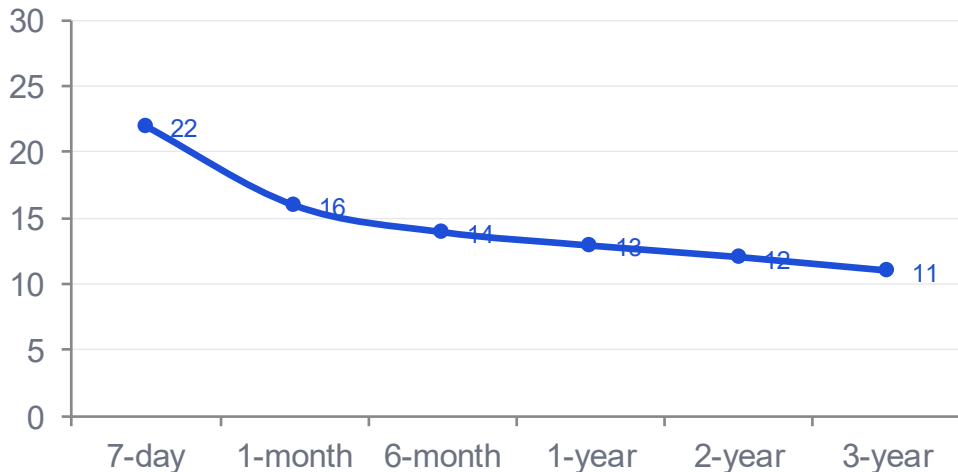
DE
Germany

KR
Korea

Users who stay, stay for years — that's exceptional

For a focus timer app, 3-year retention near zero is normal. Timer App's 11% signals deep committed loyalty.

FIG 3 — ROLLING AVERAGE RETENTION



The long-tail loyal user

11% of users subscribed after 3 years. For a niche tool with no marketing, this reflects genuine product-market fit.

What this means for strategy

Churn is concentrated in the early window. Users who reach month 1 have shown they value the product. The work is removing price friction to get them there.

FINDING — CHURN

Churn is driven by price and completion — not dissatisfaction

Of 243 quit responses, top 2 categories = 128 responses. Neither is a product failure.

FIG 4 — QUIT REASONS (N = 243)

Too expensive for my needs

I don't need it anymore

Goals accomplished with app

Switched to another product

Missing a feature I need

Technical problems

Difficult to use

69

"Too expensive for my needs"

The single largest driver of churn.

59

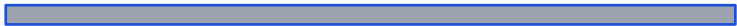
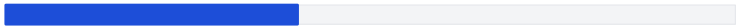
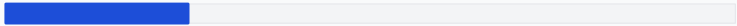
"Done and happy" churners

38 + 21 responses. Left satisfied. Natural lifecycle, not product failure.

Apple Watch leads the vote — but voting data can mislead

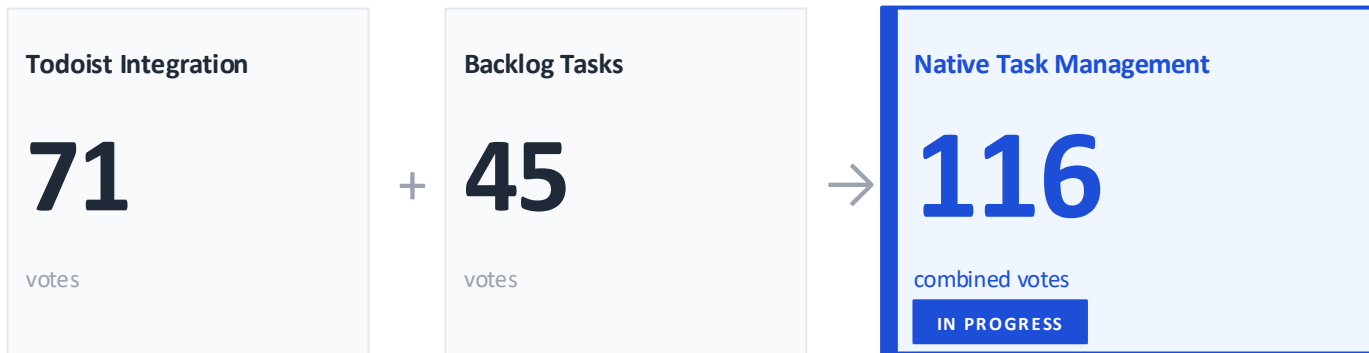
Votes don't account for feasibility, maintenance burden, or whether the feature retains the majority.

FIG 5 — FEATURE REQUESTS BY COMMUNITY VOTES (CANNY FORUM, SIMULATED MAXDIFF)

	FEATURE	RELATIVE DEMAND	VOTES
1	Apple Watch app Top request — but high maintenance, serves minority	 NOT RECOMMENDED	177
2	Time budget + burn-down chart Set weekly time limits per project		127
3	Last 365-day progress view Extend history from 30 days to a full year		89
5	Todoist integration Sync tasks — part of winning combined strategy	 PART OF WINNER	71
8	Backlog tasks / list Native to-do backlog — part of winning combined strategy	 PART OF WINNER	45

Two requests reveal the real winner: native task management

Todoist integration + Backlog tasks are both expressions of the same need — managing tasks within the flow.



Why not Apple Watch?

New codebase, high maintenance. Serves a minority of iPhone users. Distracts from the desktop core where 53% of usage happens.

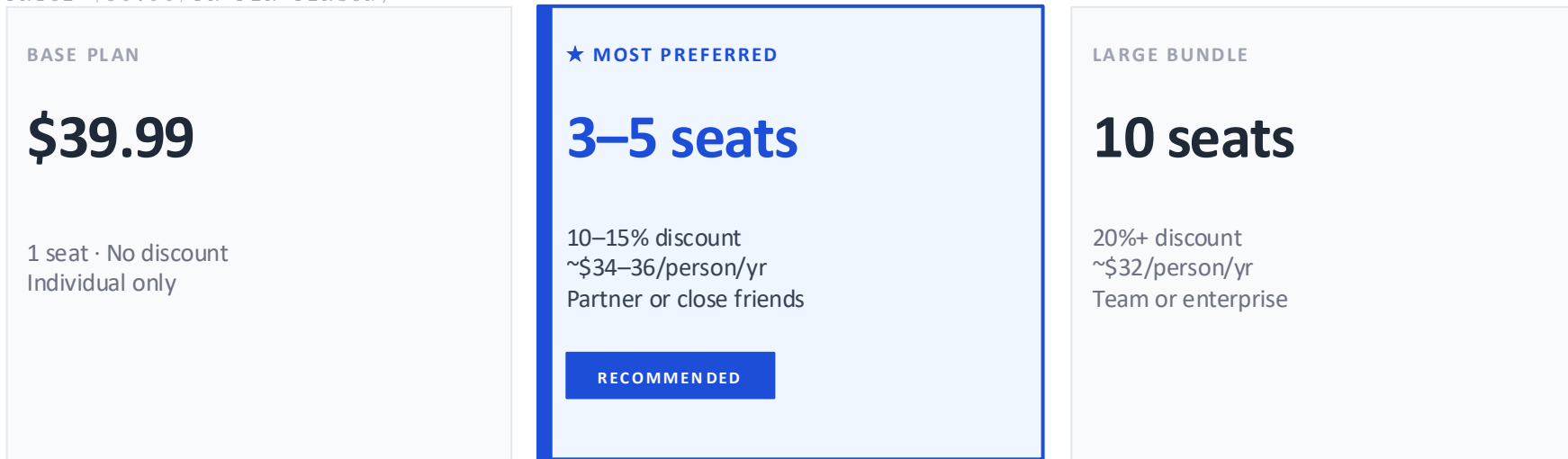
Why native tasks wins

One feature solves two high-vote needs. Builds on existing Mac codebase. Once native tasks ship, Todoist integration demand likely drops.

The right response to price sensitivity isn't a discount — it's a family plan

Lowering the base price devalues the product for everyone. A small family plan lets users share costs without eroding the individual price signal.

FIG 6 — SIMULATED CONJOINT: PREFERRED FAMILY PLAN (BASE PRICE \$39.99/YR PER PERSON)



The insight: Users don't want enterprise licenses. They want to share with a partner or close friend. 3–5 seats matches the scale of real social sharing.

STRATEGIC IMPLICATION

Every decision should optimize for the desktop core — not the vocal minority

53% of usage is on Mac. The community screaming for Apple Watch represents a minority of a minority. Data arbitrates.



Desktop-first architecture

53% Mac usage means every feature must ask: does this improve the core desktop experience? Features that only work on iPhone or Watch are always second priority.



High-impact, low-maintenance only

Philip has one engineer: himself. Every feature must be evaluated not just on demand but on the ongoing cost to maintain. Native tasks: one codebase. Apple Watch: a whole new platform.



Data over loudest voice

Apple Watch has 177 votes — the most. But combined task management has 116, serves the desktop majority, and can be built without a new platform.

Directional confidence, not statistical perfection

This research was designed for speed and actionability. Boundaries should be understood before acting on findings.

- **Simulated — not live — data for MaxDiff and Conjoint**

Canny votes used as MaxDiff proxy. Conjoint modeled from quit signals, not a controlled choice-based study. Directional, not statistically precise.

- **Self-selection bias in the quit form**

243 responses over-represent 'super fans' and 'quitters' with strong opinions. The silent middle — users who simply lapsed — is underrepresented.

- **Single researcher, no inter-rater reliability check**

Coding of quit reasons reflects one researcher's judgment. A second coder would strengthen confidence in thematic classifications.

- **Conjoint attributes were limited by design**

Only plan size and discount level tested. Price anchoring, trial periods, and offer framing were not tested and could shift preferences.

Three decisions this research can support right now

The findings are directional and actionable. Philip has already begun implementing the top recommendation.

01 Solve price friction through intimacy, not discounts

Launch a 3–5 seat family plan at 10–15% off per person. Directly addresses the #1 quit reason without devaluing the individual subscription. Target partners and close collaborators, not enterprise teams.

02 Build native task management before any platform extension

The to-do + backlog feature is already in progress. Once it ships, monitor whether Todoist demand drops — validating the underlying need hypothesis. Defer Apple Watch indefinitely unless Philip hires help.

03 Treat 'done and happy' churn as acceptable — not a problem to solve

59 of 243 quit responses describe users who got value and moved on. Energy is better spent on the 69 who left because of price than trying to re-engage satisfied completers.

Grace Feng — UX Researcher

PhD/MBA researcher with 9 years in academia and 3 years in applied UX and market research. Specializes in AI-scaled research methodologies and mixed-methods approaches.

Methods used in this project

Quit survey analysis

Simulated MaxDiff

Conjoint analysis

Mixpanel analytics

R Studio

Background

PhD, Higher Ed Leadership · Iowa State University
MBA (Thesis: LLM Chatbots) · University of Cambridge
Consulting: Redgate, Subscale · Cambridge, UK

Portfolio

grace-cambridge.github.io

Researcher positionality

Grace came to this project as a long-time Timer App user who reached out to Philip independently. This dual role — user and researcher — provided product empathy while maintaining analytical independence.

The research didn't tell Philip what to build.

It gave him the confidence to ignore the noise.

Three sources of churn noise eliminated. One real signal amplified. A solo developer can now build what matters.

FINDING 01

Price, not product

The #1 quit reason is cost. The product works. Fix the pricing model, not the app.

FINDING 02

Tasks, not Watch

116 combined votes for native task management. One codebase. Desktop majority served.

FINDING 03

Small plans, real sharing

3–5 seats at 10–15% off matches how users actually want to share — not enterprise bundles.